

More on GH

Word-final GH (review)

In Witsuwit'en, word-final **gh** can occur after these vowels: **e ē a** (in an earlier stage of the language also **o**, but no longer). The pronunciation of **gh** at the end of a word can be subtle in Witsuwit'en. At first it may sound like there is no consonant there.

so'igegh	'it turned out okay, he/she got better'
'et digegh	'that's what happened'
'et lhc'ēgh	'he/she is sitting there mad'
'et sitlēgh	'it (mushy object) is there'

GH vs. 0

Before we review some contrasts between **gh** and nothing at the end of a word, here are some words that end in a vowel:

bice	'its tail'
'et sde	'he/she is sitting there'
ye	'louse' ¹⁰

Word-final GH vs. 0

'agh 'fast, early'	'a 'fog'
bibegh 'around it, around its edge'	bibe 'for him/her'
binegh 'his/her eye'	hine 'he/she is alive'
ĩntsēgh 'he/she cried'	tsē 'rock'
ncagh 'it's big'	nc'a 'away from you'

GH vs. KH

These two back of the throat sounds are actually very similar to each other. The difference is that **gh** is produced with vibration of the vocal cords, which makes the sound louder than **kh**, which is produced with turbulent air. Compare the following contrasts before a vowel:

khikh 'goose'	bighikh 'next to it'
khiz 'pus'	bighiz 'its pus'
khiy 'root'	bighih 'its root'
khē 'grease'	bighī 'its grease'
khēlh 'pack'	bighīl 'his/her pack'

Word-final contrasts:

ndu 'enlekh? 'what are you making?'	ndu 'enlegh? 'what did you/he/she make?'
tsinīlc'ēkh 'you're getting mad'	tsinīlc'ēgh 'you/he/she got mad'
'a nididekh 'fog is disappearing'	'a nidizdegh 'fog disappeared'

¹⁰'louse' is **ye** for some speakers.

DL, TL, and TL'

Of these three phonetically similar sounds, **dl** and **tl** are somewhat rare in Witsuwit'en. They have slightly different distributions in terms of what can follow the consonant. Only **tl** is allowed at the end of a word.

DL examples

DL must be followed by a vowel in Witsuwit'en, either **u i e i** (or in theory **a**, but there are no examples of that combination). Here are some examples of **dl** before a vowel:

dlunco	'rat' ¹¹
bidluc	'its handle (semi-circular)'
ledluc, nildluc	'handbag, purse'
yilhdluh	'he/she is leading it'
k'ëndlih	'willow'
sdli, sidli	'he/she is cold'
sdlegh	'it, they (objects) (e.g. grass) died off'

DL vs. L

Compare **dl** vs. **l** in the following words:

kēnlu 'tallow'	k'ëndlih 'willow'
bilit 'its smoke'	dildlit 'he/she is hollering'
biluh 'its (fish's) air bladder'	ilhdluh 'lead, tow it (e.g. horse)'

In verbs, when **s** or **z** occurs before **l**, some speakers insert a **dl**, creating another source of examples of **dl**. But some speakers do not insert an **l**. The following words are pronounced differently by different speakers.

tēzli ~ tēzdlī	'it's flowing, water started to flow'
hozli' ~ hozdlī'	'it became', as in:
wik'iz hozli' ~ wik'iz hozdlī'	'it became cold'
c'izle ~ c'izdle	'storage area'
k'ay hozli' ~ k'ay hozdlī	'newborn (lit. it came to be recently)'
'islegh ~ 'isdlegh	'I made it'
(yis) uzlit ~ uzdlit	'snow melted'

TL examples

TL is found before the vowels **a e ē i o** as well as at the end of a word. Here are some examples of **tl** before a vowel:

witlat	'avalanche'
ditlēgh	'it (mud, ice) is soft'

¹¹Some speakers say c'ilhgicico 'rat'.

nitlëkh	‘it (mushy object) is moving around’
ïltlilh	‘he/she is jumping’
yeditlis	‘it (car) is banged up’
yintëlhtlis	‘he/she felled it (tree)’

Here are some examples of **tl** at the end of a word:

dekitl	‘safety pin’
kwin tsetl	‘spark’
bitsitl	‘its anus, eye (of needle)’
këntsitl	‘heel’

TL’ examples

Like **tl**, **tl’** is found before the vowels **a e ë i o**. Remember that **tl’**, like other consonants spelled with ‘, is released with kind of an exploding sound.

tl’a	‘and’
tl’ët	‘night’
tl’olh	‘rope’
ditl’is	‘it’s raw, fresh (meat)’
neditl’it	‘it’s dripping, leaking’
c’itl’o ~ c’itl’iw	‘he/she is knitting’

The following words with **tl’** are probably all distantly related to each other as they are similar in meaning as well as form:

bitl’a	‘his/her butt’
tl’asis ~ tl’as	‘dress, pants’
bitl’ats	‘its (boat’s) stern’
tatl’at ~ tatl’akh	‘headwater’

DL vs. TL

DL and **tl** have only partially overlapping distributions, as **dl** occurs before the vowels **e i i u** whereas **tl** occurs before **e ë a i o**.

c’idilhtlep ‘he/she is slurping something (liquid)’ yidlet ‘he’s licking it’

If followed by **i**, **dl** and **tl** have different effects on how **i** is pronounced. After **dl** the vowel **i** sounds like English “short-i” whereas after **tl**, the vowel **i** sounds like English “short-u”:

yilhtlic ‘he/she bumped into him/her/it’	wididlin ‘it’s steep’
nielhtlis ‘I’m kneading it (bread)’	tëkh dliz ‘under water plant’

TL vs. TL’

tlo ‘laughter’	tl’o ‘grass’
yinïlhtlis ‘he/she kneaded it’	yinïlhtl’is ‘she hit him on the head’

niltlikh ‘it’s jumping around’
 ’et sitlëgh ‘it (mushy object) is there’

tl'ighis 'snake'
stl'ëghe~sitl'ëghe 'my pubic hair'

DL vs. TL'

sidlet ‘it’s licking me’ sitl’et ‘he/she farted’
nec’isdlegh (~nec’islegh) ‘fish are running (cyclically)’ bitl’ëghe ‘his/her pubic hair’

After **tl'**, the vowel **i** sounds like English “short-u” just like it did after **tl**:

dildlit 'he/she is hollering'
dildlits 'it (squirrel) is chattering'
c'ilhdliz 'he's urinating something'

tl'it 'fart'
diltl'its 'it's yellow/green'
c'ilhtl'iz 'it (grouse) is drumming'

S and SI

S is one of three sounds that can form a consonant cluster in Witsuwit'en. We have seen some examples of these clusters already. Here are more examples:

skak	‘child’
skiy’	‘blood’
skiy ze’	‘young chief, chief’s son or daughter’
sdoh	‘stove’
sleghi	‘eulachon grease’
sgiz	‘he/she is breathing’
st’ë	‘it cooked (over heat)’
’et sde	‘he/she is sitting there’
scinlegh	‘timberline’
sdimon	‘humpback, pink salmon’

The first person singular possessor ‘my’ is **s-** or **si-**. You can say the following words one of two ways. Even the same speaker may use both pronunciations, unlike the words immediately above, which are pronounced as a sequence of two consonants by all native speakers.

skak, sikak	‘my skin, the surface of my body’
skiy, sikiy	‘my husband’
sle, sile	‘my hand’
slic, silic	‘my dog’
sbet, sibet	‘my mitten(s)’
sc’e’, sic’e’ (~sge’, sige’) ¹²	‘my belongings’

Likewise, the first person singular object of postposition prefix ‘me’ is **s-** or **si-**. These words can be said one of two ways:

sbe c'izu', sibe c'izu'	'it's fine with me, it looks good to me'
slegh 'ët'ën', silegh 'ët'ën'	'he/she helped me'

¹²Some speakers say belongings with **-c'e'**, others with **-ge'**.

However, if a noun or postposition begins with ' **h** or **s/z**, then usually the first person prefix is **si-** not **s-**:

si'ët	'without me'
si'usa'	'my pot'
sihalho'	'my cloth'
sizuh	'beside me'
sizil	'my body odor'

Finally, note that there are other words in Witsuwit'en that must begin with **si**. These cannot be pronounced as a cluster, with **s** directly followed by the next consonant in the word:

sinelh	'lament, mourning song'
sibo	'shame on you'
sibe	'I don't know, I wonder', as in
ndu sibe	'I don't know, I wonder what'
sili'	'he/she/it became'
siggī	'it dried out'
sikoy	'he/she threw up'
'et sibel	'it's spread out there'
'et sidzec	'they (small granular objects) are there'
'et sikay	'it (shallow container, table) is there'
'et si'ay	'it (3D object) is there'
'et sile	'they (objects) are there'

LH and LHI

Another sound that can form consonant clusters at the beginning of a word is **lh**. Here are some examples:

lhk'iy	'one'
lhk'iy ts'et	'nine'
lhkan	'tomorrow'
lhk'ats	'on both sides'
lhghen' ~ hihghen'	'evening'
sa lhk'ët'ay, lhk'ët'ay	'eclipse'
lhk'ët neent'az	'they 2 took turns'
lhdut'ën	'they (objects) look the same'
lhk'u	'smart', as in:
lhk'u nlī	'he/she is smart'
'et lhk'ëgh	'he's sitting there mad'
lhdilh	'it was shaken'
lhghil	'bundle, it's been bundled'

Note the following words too, which begin with **lhi**, not **lh**+consonant:

lhiyil
lhikit
lhilen'a
lhiyiye
lhisikwiz

'it's white'
'he/she is clapping'
'suit'
'he/she walked through'
'he/she drove through'

Writing practice 6

_____ or _____

_____ or _____

'my cat'

'different place'

'raft'

'he/she is lying there'

'he/she is standing there'

'my spine'

'string' (lit. 'it's twisted')

'area under standing tree'

'whole, entire'

'how big is it?'

'on both sides'

'skunk'

'many people'

'jump in'

'rosehip'

'it (e.g. butter) is melting'

'we (2) are sitting there'

'he/she painted it'

'he/she ran through'

'bald eagle'

'he/she, you blamed me'

'back and forth'

'he's pressing his lips together'

'you owe me money'

'eclipse'

'take it apart'

_____	‘he/she’s afraid’
_____	‘I’m afraid’
_____	‘I became afraid, got scared’

When you have finished, compare what you wrote with your neighbor and try to come to some agreement.

Answers to writing practice 6

sdus or sidus
 lhe'it
 wiyis
 'et stiy
 'et siy'in
 syin or siyin
 sdidiz
 scenyik
 dilco
 delco
 lhedik
 holits
 lhanī
 dīltlat
 tselhghil
 hitghekh
 'et sditkē
 yidiztl'is
 lhilhggec
 sggigit
 sk'ëon'ay
 lhdiyī
 lhdesigim
 sts'ozilh'ay
 lhk'ëlts'it
 lhkalhkat
 nilgit
 nigilgit
 nīzigilgut

'my cat'
 'difference place'
 'raft'
 'he or she is lying there'
 'he/she is standing there'
 'my spine'
 'string' (lit. 'it's twisted')
 'area under standing tree'
 'whole, entire'
 'how big is it?'
 'on both sides'
 'skunk'
 'many people'
 'jump in'
 'rosehip'
 'it (e.g. butter) is melting'
 'we (2) are sitting there'
 'he/she painted it'
 'he/she ran through'
 'bald eagle'
 'he/she, you blamed me'
 'back and forth'
 'he's pressing his lips together'
 'you owe me money'
 'eclipse'
 'take it apart'
 'he/she's afraid'
 'I'm afraid'
 'I became afraid, got scared'